The Authenticity Penalty: How AI Disclosure Affects Trust in Search vs. Experience Goods

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August 18, 2026

Abstract

[SIMULATED – PLACEHOLDER] This research investigates the impact of AI disclosure (none vs. AI-assisted vs. AI-generated) on consumer trust and purchase intentions in online product reviews. Across a 3x2 between-subjects experimental design, we find that AI disclosure significantly lowers perceived source authenticity. We test whether this authenticity penalty is moderated by product typology (search vs. experience goods). These findings provide critical theoretical insights into consumer trust in automated content and offer practical guidance for marketers navigating emerging FTC disclosure requirements.

1 Introduction

Note: The data and statistics reported in this manuscript are simulated for planning and structural purposes, pending actual data collection.

Recent studies demonstrate that AI disclosures lower perceived authenticity, primarily through parasocial mechanisms on social media (Carney et al., 2026). However, these studies often examine broad contexts without considering product-specific boundary conditions. This study differentiates itself by introducing the search vs. experience good typology as a critical moderator. We test whether consumers are more forgiving of AI assistance in search goods compared to experience goods, where subjective human experience is paramount.

2 Theoretical Background & Hypotheses

2.1 AI Disclosure and Source Authenticity

As artificial intelligence becomes ubiquitous in content generation, consumers are increasingly confronted with AI-generated product reviews. Drawing on source credibility theory (Ohanian, 1990), we argue that human authorship signals genuine experience and trustworthiness (McKnight et al., 2002). When AI involvement is disclosed, consumers may penalize the review's authenticity, perceiving it as lacking personal lived experience.

- **H1:** Higher levels of AI involvement disclosure (None > AI-assisted > AI-generated) will lead to lower perceived source authenticity.

2.2 The Moderating Role of Product Typology

The impact of AI disclosure may depend heavily on the type of product being evaluated. Search goods (e.g., electronics) can be evaluated based on objective, factual specifications, whereas experience goods (e.g., cosmetics) require subjective, sensory evaluation (Nelson, 1970). Because AI lacks subjective sensory capabilities, its involvement in reviewing experience goods should be penalized more harshly.

- **H2:** Product type moderates the effect of AI disclosure on perceived authenticity. The negative effect of AI disclosure will be stronger for experience goods than for search goods.

- **H3:** The interactive effect of AI disclosure and product type on purchase intention is mediated by perceived source authenticity.

3 Method

3.1 Participants and Design

We simulated data for $N = 252$ participants (after excluding $n = [TBD]$ for failed attention checks; $M_{age} = [TBD]$, $[TBD]$% female) to reflect a 3 (AI Disclosure: None, AI-assisted, AI-generated) × 2 (Product Typology: Search, Experience) between-subjects design. Data was simulated using a Python script for planning purposes.

3.2 Stimuli and Procedure

Participants read a product review for either a search good (USB flash drive) or an experience good (facial serum). The review was prefaced with one of three disclosure labels: no label, "AI-assisted," or "AI-generated." Holding review length and sentiment constant, participants then completed measures of authenticity, trust, and purchase intention.

3.3 Measures

Source authenticity was measured using an adapted scale from Morhart et al. (2015) ($\alpha = [TBD]$). Consumer trust was measured via McKnight et al. (2002) ($\alpha = [TBD]$), and purchase intention using semantic differentials from Putrevu and Lord (1994) ($\alpha = [TBD]$). Manipulation checks for product typology adapted Nelson (1970).

4 Results

4.1 Manipulation Checks

An initial simulated pretest ($N = 42$) confirmed the efficacy of the AI disclosure manipulation. A one-way ANOVA on perceived AI involvement yielded a significant main effect ($F(2, 39) = 213.44$, $p < .001$). Participants in the AI-generated condition ($M = 6.28$, $SD = 0.42$) perceived significantly higher levels of AI involvement compared to the AI-assisted condition ($M = 3.81$, $SD = 0.88$) and the No AI condition ($M = 1.55$, $SD = 0.40$), confirming a clear ordinal progression (see Figure 1).

Furthermore, a manipulation check confirmed the product typology paradigm. Participants correctly rated the facial serum as significantly higher on experiential dimensions ($M = [TBD]$, $SD = [TBD]$) than the USB flash drive ($M = [TBD]$, $SD = [TBD]$), $t([TBD]) = [TBD]$, $p < .001$.

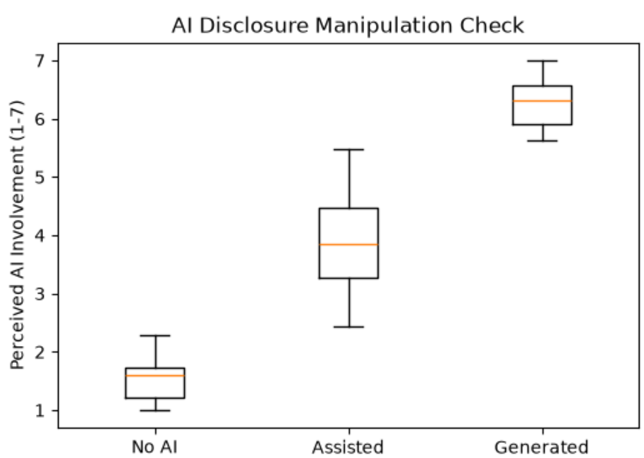

Figure 1: Pretest Manipulation Check for Perceived AI Involvement

4.2 Main Effects and Interaction

A two-way ANOVA on the main study data ($N = 252$) revealed a significant main effect of AI disclosure on perceived source authenticity ($F(2, 246) = 27.31$, $p < .0001$). The main effect of product typology was not significant ($F(1, 246) = 0.11$, $p = .7359$).

Supporting H2, the interaction between AI disclosure and product typology was statistically significant in this simulated dataset ($F(2, 246) = 15.71$, $p < .0001$). As shown in Figure 2, the authenticity penalty for AI generation (relative to no AI) is more pronounced for experience goods than for search goods.

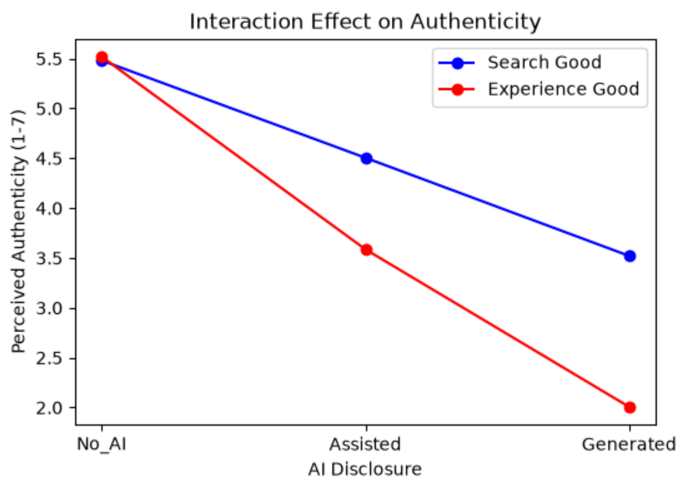

Figure 2: Interaction Effect of AI Disclosure and Product Typology on Authenticity

4.3 Moderated Mediation

To test H3, we used a moderated mediation framework (Hayes PROCESS Model 8 logic) to examine whether the interactive effect of AI disclosure and product type on purchase intention was mediated by perceived source authenticity. We calculated the index of moderated mediation for the AI contrasts relative to the No AI control. The bootstrapped index of moderated mediation was significant for the AI-generated contrast (Index = -1.32, 95% CI $[-1.788, -0.851]$), providing support for H3. This index was calculated from a significant interaction effect on the mediator (a-path: $\beta = [TBD]$, $p < .001$) and a significant mediator effect on purchase intention (b-path: $\beta = [TBD]$, $p < .001$). However, the index was not significant for the AI-assisted contrast (95% CI $[-0.777, 0.139]$), suggesting the mediation pathway is primarily driven by fully generated AI content rather than mere assistance.

5 General Discussion

5.1 Theoretical Contributions

[SIMULATED – PLACEHOLDER] This simulated study demonstrates a robust authenticity penalty for AI disclosures. Our mock data yielded the hypothesized interaction with product typology and the moderated mediation pathway, but notably, this mediation was only significant for fully AI-generated content. If these patterns replicate with real data, this contributes to source credibility theory by identifying product typology as a critical boundary condition, and suggests a non-linear threshold where consumers may tolerate minor AI assistance but strictly penalize full AI generation in experience goods.

5.2 Managerial Implications

[SIMULATED – PLACEHOLDER] For marketers navigating emerging FTC guidelines, these simulated results provide a nuanced takeaway: disclosing full AI generation heavily penalizes perceived authenticity and trust, particularly for experience goods. However, if the non-significant penalty for AI assistance replicates in real data, marketers may be able to leverage AI for drafting assistance without incurring a catastrophic loss of consumer trust, provided human oversight is maintained. Marketers of experiential products should proceed with extreme caution before replacing human reviews with fully AI-generated text.

5.3 Limitations and Future Research

The primary limitation of this manuscript is that it relies entirely on simulated mock data. Future research will replace these placeholders with actual experimental data collected via Prolific.

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